percent and rising to ₹130 crores. Earnings per share rose to ₹114 from ₹81 and total assets rose to ₹4,060 crores. HDFC's total loan approvals touched the ₹5,500 crore mark and disbursements ₹4,500 crores. The dividend that year touched a record 28 percent. The acorn which Parekh had sown had become a mighty oak. Parekh, humble and soft-spoken as ever, must certainly have felt a warm glow of achievement as he laid down office.

Given the great success of HDFC, the boldness of Parekh's enterprise is less apparent. What was in effect established was a financial institution that intended to raise long-term resources (which are generally difficult to raise), finance households directly (which no institution had done before on any substantial scale), service the loans efficiently (in the absence of any legally practicable way of foreclosing on mortgages), and not only remain viable commercially but also enhance shareholder value consistently. As it entered its silver jubilee year, HDFC led an industry. It had a balance sheet size of over ₹17,800 crores, cumulative loan approvals and disbursements of ₹31,095 crores, and ₹25,953 crores respectively and had financed over 17.6 lakhs units. Its launch on Dussehra day had proved auspicious indeed.

POSTSCRIPT

If H.T. Parekh pioneered the idea of housing finance, it was Deepak Parekh who executed it to perfection, not only growing HDFC but also setting up a bank, a mutual fund, a securities company, two insurance companies, and India's largest real estate private equity firm after he took over from his uncle as Chairman. Over the years, HDFC has emerged as a financial conglomerate with its presence in the entire gamut of financial services including banking, insurance (life and non-life), asset management, real estate venture capital, and more recently education loans. And over the years, Deepak has been more than just a leader of a professionally-run organization. He has been called several times to handle crises, most recently the Satyam fraud and he is the first confidante for most people coming to India to do business. His office is one of two or three stops for top global businessmen and officials visiting India.

By the time Parekh retired, the Indian economy had witnessed a major turnaround in the balance-of-payments situation. Many of the initial effects of economic reform were felt in the financial sector through major foreign